

Two problems I'd like to research

- A. The important notifications get lost among everything else
- B. Losing your place after switching between apps

A. The important notifications get lost among everything else

Pretty much anyone with a phone and a laptop, and it's worse if you message a lot or own more than one device.

What goes wrong

Every app gets to decide how urgent it is, so a message from your mom shows up the same way as a 20% off sale. You either check everything constantly, or you mute stuff and miss the things that actually mattered. Apple and Google have started ranking notifications on-device, but so far only on the newest phones, and there isn't really anything on desktop.

How it plays out

App decides how urgent it is → OS delivers it to every device → you glance and read the preview → now, later, or swipe → **get back to what you were doing**

Apps rate their own urgency, and every time one pulls you for nothing you pay the time to get back.

237

notifications a day, median for teens

Common Sense Media, Constant Companion, 2023

47 s

average screen attention before switching

Gloria Mark, UC Irvine

23 min

to fully get back after an interruption

Mark, Gudith, Klocke, CHI 2008

A. What I've found so far, and the plan

Already out there

- Apple Priority Notifications (iOS 18.4), on-device ranking, iPhone 15 Pro and up only, off by default
- Android 16 notification organizer and summaries, Pixel 9 and 10 only
- Focus modes and Do Not Disturb on every OS, all rule-based and rarely revisited
- Third-party managers like BuzzKill and FilterBox, Android only

Biggest unknowns

- What fraction of notifications actually get acted on, by category and platform
- Whether missing one urgent message costs more than all the interruptions it saves
- What a third-party app can even see per OS, and iOS doesn't really give you anything

Plan to Oct 19 (public sources only)

Task	When	Hours
Platform capability audit (Apple, Google, Microsoft docs)	Sep 24 to 27	4
Literature review, Scopus, 10 to 12 papers	Sep 27 to Oct 2	6
Benchmark OS features and 6 to 8 third-party managers	Oct 2 to 5	4
Tag 80 to 100 Reddit, Hacker News and app store posts	Oct 5 to 9	4
Analogous contexts: priority inbox, ICU alarm fatigue	Oct 9 to 11	2
Synthesis: stakeholder map, journey map, gap list	Oct 11 to 15	4
Milestone 3 write-up	Oct 15 to 18	4

Questions for you

1. Is the desktop pile a different problem from the phone pile?
2. What sources am I missing outside of HCI papers?
3. Is missing one urgent message worse than all the interruptions it saves?

B. Losing your place after switching between apps

Students and knowledge workers who have one task spread across tabs, chats, docs, a terminal and notes.

What goes wrong

When you switch, because someone messaged you or you just wandered off, there isn't really anything that saves where you were. Getting back means finding the tabs and the thread again and re-reading to remember what you were doing, and some stuff never gets picked back up. The tools that try to help either restore your window layout, or they record everything and set off a privacy backlash.

How it plays out

Working on A → a ping, or you wander off → open stuff for B → **try to go back: what was it? where are the tabs?** → resume A with B still in your head

There isn't really anything that saves where you were, so you end up carrying the context between your own apps yourself.

2.5 min → 47 s

screen attention, 2004 vs now

[Gloria Mark, UC Irvine](#)

25 min

to get back, usually via 2+ other tasks

[Mark, Gonzalez, Harris, CHI 2005](#)

275

interruptions a day at work

[Microsoft Work Trend Index, 2025](#)

B. What I've found so far, and the plan

Already out there

- Windows Recall screenshots everything, got delayed a year over security and is still flagged in 2026
- Rewind.ai did the same on Mac, then pivoted to a pendant in 2024
- Stage Manager, virtual desktops, tab groups, Workona and Session Buddy only bring the layout back
- IDE workspaces bring the files back, and you still have to remember why you had them open

Biggest unknowns

- How much of getting back is finding your stuff vs rebuilding the mental model
- Which signals are enough (titles, URLs, clipboard, chat thread) and where the line between useful and creepy is
- Whether session managers fail because they can't do it or because nobody adopts them

Plan to Oct 19 (public sources only)

Task	When	Hours
Literature review, Scopus, 10 to 12 papers	Sep 24 to 30	6
Benchmark 8 to 10 restore tools incl. Recall, Rewind, Arc	Sep 30 to Oct 4	4
Code the Recall backlash by objection type	Oct 4 to 7	3
Platform capability audit (Windows, macOS, browsers)	Oct 7 to 10	3
Tag 60 to 80 Reddit and Hacker News posts	Oct 10 to 13	3
Synthesis: journey map, stakeholder map, gap list	Oct 13 to 16	4
Milestone 3 write-up	Oct 16 to 18	3

Questions for you

1. Where's the line between a helpful memory and surveillance?
2. Is this a capability gap or an adoption gap?
3. Should this merge with the notifications one or stay separate?